



OREGON YOUTH AUTHORITY

Policy Statement

Part III – Youth Services (Community)



Subject:

English Plus – Youth (Community)

Section – Policy Number:

A: General Administration – 2.2

Supersedes:

III-A-2.2 (04/16)

III-A-2.2 (11/11)

III-A-2.2 (11/07)

Effective Date:

04/26/2024

Date of Last

Review:

04/26/2026

Related Standards and References:

- [The Civil Rights Act of 1964 \(Titles VI and VII\)](#) and [The Civil Rights Act of 1991](#)
- [English Plus Resolution](#) Reintroduced 1997
- [OAR Chapter 416, Division 20](#) Youth in Custody Grievance Process
- [OYA policy](#): I-D-2.1 Use of Language Services
- [OYA form](#): YA 1501 Request for Translation Services – for written documents
YA 1502 Request for Interpretation Services – for spoken/sign language

Related Procedures:

- None

Policy Owner:

Office of Inclusion and Intercultural Relations (OIIR) Director

Approved:


Joseph O'Leary, Director

I. PURPOSE:

This policy provides guidelines for youth, youth families and staff communication in languages other than English. This policy is also applicable to the use of signing by deaf or hard of hearing youth and their families or visitors.

II. POLICY DEFINITIONS:

Bilingual: Using or able to use two languages especially with equal fluency.

Limited English Proficient (LEP): LEP individuals, as a result of national origin, are limited in their English proficiency.

- Many LEP individuals are in the process of learning English and may read, write, speak, and/or understand some English, but not proficiently.
- LEP status may be context-specific – an individual may have sufficient English language skills to communicate basic information (name, address etc.) but may not have sufficient English-speaking skills to communicate detailed information (e.g., medical information, treatment groups,

Multidisciplinary Treatment meetings, eyewitness accounts, information elicited in an interview) in English.

III. POLICY:

OYA has identified diversity, equity and inclusion as an agency priority and initiative, with a goal to build a respectful, diverse, equitable and inclusive environment for youth and staff that is free from harassment, discrimination and bias. OYA is aware of the growing diversity of its staff and youth. OYA values and supports language diversity and seeks to provide language-specific and culturally-appropriate services to youth and their families. Even though a youth may understand English at a survival level, the youth may not be at a level that permits adequate comprehension of spoken or written English.

Staff must be aware of the growing language diversity of OYA staff and youth and the need to, at times, use a language other than English. Communication in a youth's native language is encouraged and acceptable among youth, between youth and staff, and youth and their families.

IV. GENERAL STANDARDS:

- A. Youth have a right to communicate with each other and others in their native languages.
- B. Bilingual staff who have been identified by OYA Human Resources Office as fluent in languages in addition to English must be readily available to facilitate communication between staff and youth (or youth families) who are Limited English Proficient (LEP), non-English-speaking, or deaf or hard of hearing.

See OYA policy I-D-2.1 Use of Language Services for interpreter and translator guidelines.

- C. Youth rights and responsibilities must be reviewed with LEP and non-English-speaking youth in their native languages.

Staff must provide youth contact information to seek assistance from the Office of Inclusion and Intercultural Relations.

- D. Staff will encourage youth to learn English while in OYA custody.
- E. Staff may only use youth as interpreters in unforeseeable emergencies while waiting for an authorized interpreter.
- F. Questions related to this policy, its interpretation or development may be directed to the Office of Inclusion and Intercultural Relations.

V. LOCAL OPERATING PROTOCOL REQUIRED: NO